

Reflections of Buddhist Philosophy in Rabindranath Tagore's Literature

Buddha and his philosophy played an important role in Tagore's spiritual outlook. He was greatly influenced by it in the most literal sense. It had been his second source of inspiration after Upanishads in his life. He holds Lord Buddha in his heart as the greatest of men ever born on this earth. The Buddha's teachings were earth-bound, rational, and pragmatic. Buddha's humanistic philosophy gave universal respect for all humanity in all the countries.

In this paper, an attempt will be made to analyse, how under the influence of Buddhist philosophy, Tagore executed Buddhist *Jatak Kathas*, ethical themes in his poems, Plays, Essays, travelogues, ballads, novels, short stories, and lectures and how the everlasting message of Buddhism is reflected through his whole literature. To accomplish this goal, I have organized my paper into six main sections, three of which have sub-sections. In the first section I present biographical information about Rabindranath Tagore. In the second section, I have attempted to brief about Buddha and his Teachings, it has sub-section, which highlights Buddhist Philosophy in Nutshell.

In the third section, I focus on the influence of Buddha's philosophy on Tagore; in its sub-section I provide the principal sources of Buddhist Philosophy for Tagore. In fourth Section, in detail I talk about the reflections of Buddhist Philosophy in Tagore's literature; it has three sub sections i.e. Poems, Novels and Plays. In fifth section, I discuss Tagore's view about Buddha and Buddhism; it has two sub-sections i.e. Shantiniketan and Buddhist holy sites: In India and abroad. In the last i.e. sixth section, I come to the conclusion, which offers over all finding of this paper.

GURUDEV RABINDRANATH TAGORE:

Rabindranath Tagore (7th May, 1861 - 7th August, 1941) was an Indian poet, a litterateur par excellence, a philosopher, religious thinker and intellectual leader, songwriter, musician, artist, educational reformer, a great exponent of humanity with a firm footing in his own cultural environment, one of the finest flowers of Indian Renaissance and India's herald of Peace and harmony to the world; he was the first non-European to win the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1913 for his anthology, *Gitanjali* (Song Offerings) (1912), translated by him from Bengali into English. There was hardly any literary form that he did not touch upon and turn into gold. His creativity found best expressions in his poems, plays, novels, essays, short stories, satirical pieces, textbooks for children, and songs of all kind.

He established an international University Visva Bharati at Santiniketan, on the model of the Buddhist *Viharas* (Monasteries) which was great center of learning in those days, through this Visva Bharati he promoted spiritual values and the creation of a new world culture founded in multi-culturalism, diversity and tolerance. He also built an experimental school for children at Santiniketan (Abode of Peace).

In his life time, he traveled widely in Europe and Asian countries giving lectures on India's spiritual heritage. He was perhaps the only litterateur who penned anthems of two countries i.e. India's *Jana Gana Mana* and Bangladesh's *Amar Shonar Bangla*.

Lord Buddha and his Philosophy (Buddhism)

*Buddha--the flower of mankind is no more in this world, but the sweet fragrance of His peace message remains forever.*¹ (K. Sri Dhammananda Ch.2)

¹ The Lord Gautama Buddha passed away more than two thousand years ago, but his teachings still remain and will forever remain in this world. Source: <http://www.budsas.org/ebud/whatbudbeliev/28.htm>

Gautama, the Buddha (the enlightened one), before his enlightenment he was called Prince Siddharth Gautam, who was born of the Sakya clan in the year of 623 B.C some 2500 years ago at a place called Lumbini, which is located in modern day Nepal and neighbouring area of Northern India. At the age of twenty-nine, Prince Siddhartha left the comfort and affluence of his father's palace to adopt the life of a wandering ascetic.

He had been perturbed due to number of questions of life, therefore, he wanted to understand the existential problems of birth, sickness, death, aging and unhappiness, and to search for a possible way or a remedy to exterminate and overcome these sufferings and liberate all humanity from it. In the search of an answer, he broke away from the traditional religious practices of the time to find the path out of suffering for himself; therefore, he followed the path of the middle way (golden mean), avoiding the two extremes of over-indulgence and severe austerity and attained enlightenment at Buddha Gaya and found the answers.

Buddha's Philosophy in Nutshell

In May 1956, BBC,London² broadcast a talk of Dr.Babasaheb alias Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar, Great Indian scholar, nationalist, jurist, political leader, Buddhist revivalist and an architect of the Indian Constitution, in his talk titled *"Why I like Buddhism and how it is useful to the world in its present circumstances"* he expressed his thoughts on Buddhism,:

I prefer Buddhism because it gives three principles in combination, which no other religion does. All other religions are bothering themselves with God and Soul and life after death. Buddhism teaches prajna (understanding as against superstition and supernaturalism), karuna (love), and samata (equality). This is what man wants for a good and happy life. These three principles of Buddhism make appeal to me. These

² British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC): It is a British Public service broadcaster; it is the world's oldest national broadcasting organization.

three principles should also make an appeal to the world. Neither god nor soul can save society (Madan 205)

Gautama the Buddha, after his attainment of enlightenment delivered three discourses at three places which came to be known as the ‘Three Turnings of the Wheel of the Dharma’. The first discourse which was on the theme of the ‘Four Noble Truths’ given at place called Saranath in modern day Banaras, this discourse became the foundation of all Buddhist thought and practice. His second discourse was on the theme of the ‘Perfection of Wisdom’ given at Vulture Peak, located in the city of Rajgriha in modern day Bihar, this discourse deals with the ultimate nature of reality, establishing how things do not have intrinsic or real existence. His third discourse was on the theme of ‘Thorough Discrimination’ which took place at Vaishali in modern day northeast India, this discourse was mainly clarification on teachings from his two earlier sets of discourses.

Basically Buddhist philosophy/Buddhism was originally a response to the problem of suffering. Buddha’s answer to this problem is contained in the Sutra of Four Noble Truths and the Sutra of Eightfold Path.

Four Noble Truths: (1) There is suffering (2) suffering has specific and identifiable causes (i.e.in ignorance, attachment and hatred) (3) suffering can be ended (4) the way to end suffering is through enlightened living as expressed in the Eightfold Path.

The most immediate causes of human suffering are ignorance and selfish craving. The Path leading to this release of suffering is to practice Dharma; the quality of life depends not upon external development or material progress, but upon the inner development of peace and happiness.

Eightfold Path: (1) Right view (2) right aim (3) right speech; (4) right action (5) right living (6) right effort (7) right mindfulness (8) right contemplation.

Through meditation and self-abnegation, encouragement to better lives, finally *nirvana* (a permanent state of supreme enlightenment and serenity that ends the cycle of reincarnation) is obtained.

The quintessence of Buddha's complete teaching is the interdependent nature of all things, and the moral ethics of non-violence, the discipline of self-restraint and values such as individualism, social equality and self-emancipation, the law of cause and effect and middle path. Through friendship, compassion and the universal love Buddha destroyed the barriers that separated human beings from other human beings, He says that every single human being has the ultimate potential to attain the supreme goal of Buddhahood if he has the determination and will to do so.

Buddha's teachings are still significant and relevant to the needs of present-day burning problems, while emphasizing his views about practicing Buddha's teaching Geshe Kelsang Gyatso, in his book, *Introduction to Buddhism: An explanation of the Buddhist way of life* (1999) tells us:

If we integrate Buddha's teachings into our daily life we will be able to solve all our inner problems and attain a truly peaceful mind. (Gyatso 9)

INFLUENCE OF BUDDHA'S PHILOSOPHY ON TAGORE

At the time of Tagore's birth, important changes were taking place, *Brāhmo Samāj* (Society of the Absolute) was already founded by Raja Rammohan Roy in 1828. This was first modern Hindu reform and progressive movement. Later on the *Tattwabodhinī Sabhā* (Truth Propagating/Searching Society) was found in 29th September 1839 by Debendranath Tagore, Ashkay Kumar Datta, Ishwarachandra Vidyasagar, Ramachandra Vidyasagar and Ram Gopal Ghosh. The important rationale of the *Sabhā* was to promote a more balanced and

humanist form of Hinduism based on the Vedānta, the Upanishads that form the last part of the Vedās.

Tagore's father, Debendranath, propagated a monotheistic religion based on the Upanishads. Rabindranath too was greatly influenced by Advaita Vedanta. However, he was too independent to connect to the rigidity of any institutional belief or creed as he was associated with *Brāhmo Samāj*, he did not believe in Idol worship.

It was his family that influenced the religious/spiritual inclination of Tagore's mind towards Buddhism. There were number of incidents which directly or indirectly influencing Tagore's psyche i.e. a movement which was launched in 1890's by Anagarika Dharmapala, the great Colombo-born Buddhist and the founder of the *Mahabodhi* Society in Calcutta. After a period of 2000 years Buddhism had receded from India and that is why Dharmapala had a noble vision to revive Buddhism in the land of its origin. To understand Buddhist philosophy and Buddhist literature, Tagore studied Rajendralal Mitra's *The Sanskrit Buddhist Literature of Nepal* (1882).

Buddha and his philosophy played an important role in Tagore's spiritual outlook. He was greatly influenced by it in the most literal sense. It was given by a human being to human beings. The Buddha's teachings were earth-bound, rational, and pragmatic. Tagore always respected Buddhist Principles and values and earnestly, passionately used it in his literature at large. He had accepted Buddha as his ideal and inspiration. Throughout his life, he had the deepest reverence for Lord Buddha, in his observation; the teaching of Buddha is a humanistic philosophy which gives universal respect for all humanity in all countries.

Tagore never dwelled over abstract philosophy of Buddhism, nor did he delve upon the issue of suffering (*dukkha*). Buddha's teachings addressed human problems, the human malaise, human suffering. Tagore just took up Buddha's positive message, a life of commitment with love and joy; living the present moment, for him Buddha was always non-

escapism from worldly affairs. After visiting South East Asia and Far East in July 1927, he more inclined towards Buddhist Humanistic Principles and due to that great influence of Buddhist philosophy, he had employed many Buddhist *Jatak Kathas*³ ethical themes in his poems, Plays, Essays, travelogues, ballads, novels, short stories, and lectures.

Principal Sources of Buddhist philosophy for Tagore

The first and major source of Buddhist Philosophy had been one of the first prominent Indian indologists Rajendralal Mitra's *The Sanskrit Buddhist Literature of Nepal* (1882) which he used to quote anecdotes and legends about Buddha in his poems, Plays, Essays, travelogues, ballads, novels, short stories, and lectures. He had also used many Buddhist tales from the brief English summaries of lengthy Sanskrit texts like the Avadana-shataka, Mahavastu-avadana, Shardulakarna-avadana, and Kalpadruma-avadana.

Tagore's second source was the book by Teitaro Suzuki: *Outlines of Mahayana Buddhism* (1907). This was one of the first English summaries of the theologies and philosophical doctrines of Mahayana Buddhism.

The third source is Ashvaghosha's Sanskrit epic on the life of Buddha, the *Buddhacarita*. (1936) of this epic some parts have survived in Sanskrit.

Along with these sources the books of Edwin Arnold⁴ (1832-1904) an epic life-story of the Buddha in verse under the title *Light of Asia* (1879) and Kakuzo Okakura⁵, *The Awakening of Asia* (1905), *The Ideals of the East* (1903).

Tagore time and again quoted Buddhist texts directly from *Theravada* canon in Pali, the *Mangala Sutta*, the *Metta Sutta* and the *Dhammapada*.

³ The stories and legends of the births of Buddha, which immortalizes 547 stories of Buddha's former births compiled in the *Tipitaka texts*

⁴ The British minor poet, journalist and the Principal of Deccan College, Poona

⁵ The Japanese Visitor who had come to India

REFLECTIONS OF BUDDHIST PHILOSOPHY IN TAGORE'S LITERATURE

The focus of the researcher will be to analyse critically and illustrate how the reflections of Buddhist teachings /philosophy are used in Tagore's various works. Tagore was really impressed by Buddha's Philosophy, so his writings have discrete trajectory, the impact of teachings of Buddha and that had been his second source of inspiration after Upanishads in his life, therefore, in the preface of his first English book of religious essays, he states:

To me the verses of the Upanishads and the teachings of Buddha have ever been things of the spirit, and therefore endowed with boundless vital growth; and I have used them, both in my own life and in my preaching (Tagore Vol.2:278)

So far, his leaning towards Vedas, Upanishads had been highlighted, however, the second source i.e. Buddhism was not emphasized much. Here Tagore clearly acknowledged his closeness to Buddhism and told that it had been the source of his spirituality forever. Tagore handled many Buddhist themes in poems, ballads, novels, short stories, and plays, for example, the poems '*Abhisar*' (Love's Sojourn), '*Mulya Prapti*' (Receipt of Price), '*Mastak Vikray*' (Sale of the Head), '*Sreshtha Bhiksha*' (Best gift of Begging),

'*Parishodh*' (Repayment of Loan), '*Dinadan*' (poor gift), '*Chandalika*', were based on Buddhistic episodes and exhibited the glory of renunciation. Possibly it was like amidst the misery and turmoil in the world, Tagore had come to sing Buddha songs which were recited 2500 years ago.

He also respected the everlasting merits of Buddhism through the *Malini*, *Chandalika* and *Natir Puja*, (The Dancing Girl's Worship), His three dramas and a novel *Ghare Baire*

(Home & World) based on Buddhist stories. Gautam Buddha and his philosophy had stirred his imaginations time and again through his long successful creative career. He devoted his number of poems to Buddhist philosophy and tried to explore what Buddha meant to him.

Poems:

Through his famous poem “To the Buddha” which is translated in to English by him, he aptly gives indication of how much he respects Buddha and how he beseeches to Buddha to wipe away “all dark stains” from hearts of this earth:

To The Buddha

"The world today is wild with the delirium of hatred,
the conflicts are cruel and unceasing in anguish,
crooked are its paths, tangled its bonds of greed.
All creatures are crying for a new birth of thine,
Oh thou of boundless life,
Save them, raise thine eternal voice of hope,
Let love's lotus with its inexhaustible treasure of honey
Open its petals in thy light.
O Serene, O Free,
in thine immeasurable mercy and goodness
wipe away all dark stains from the heart of this earth.
Thou giver of immortal gifts,
Give us the power of renunciation,
And claim from us our pride.
In the splendour of a new surprise of wisdom
let the blind gain their sight

and let life come to the souls that are dead.

O Serene, O Free,

in thine immeasurable mercy and goodness,

wipe away all dark stains from hearts of this earth. (Ray Vol.1:213-214)

The poem demonstrates how Tagore has realized the importance Buddha's everlasting, peaceful teaching for humanity. He tells that the entire world today is wild with the delirium of hatred, selfishness, malaise, jealousy, comparison, conflict and rivalry which are cruel and unceasing in anguish. In such wretched condition the only consolation is the Buddha; an epitome of peace and non-violence. In this poem, Tagore sees Buddha as the vim and vigor of peacefulness, wholesomeness, symbol of love, goodness, compassion, wisdom and ever inspiring hope of the mankind.

The Buddha was so compassionate and sensitive enough that he was ever ready to sacrifice his entire life to save the life of an ant. This humanism of Buddha made an impact on the mind of Tagore, who also propagated universal humanism, compassion and friendliness through his poems; Tagore rightly encapsulates this Buddhist humanist approach in his poem:

Nagarlakshmi

My store is lying full,

In the houses of each of you,

If you want,

This begging bowl should be ever full,

I will save the earth with the food given as alms,

Thus I shall quench the hunger of famine. (Ray Vol.1:227)

This poem depicts the modesty and generosity of a Buddhist nun Supriya and the influence of Buddhist humanism. She takes the responsibility to provide food to the starving people of Sravasti, though she is just a beggar woman, she offers food willingly to that hungry needy people.

Pujarini (*She who offers worship, 1899*)

Tagore has employed many Buddhist tales and historical events in his literature. A tale of King Bimbisara, King Ajatshatru and Sreemati, a poor dancing girl, who sacrifices her life for worship at the feet of Lord Buddha.

Tagore has very dexterously turned this tale into a poem, *Pujarini, She who offers worship* (in *Katha* published in 1900). King Bimbisara's queens worship the Stupa, in this poem the incidents after the demise of Bimbisara are portrayed. He usurps the throne and becomes the king, King Bimbisara's son King Ajatashatru murders his father and moves to Vedic Brahmanism as a result that, Buddha's worship is forbidden. However, a poor girl, Shrimati, a servant of the queens wants to worship, despite queens' warnings, she remains firm and in the night lights the small lamp in front of Stupa, for this act of worship she is punished and that autumn night sees the quenching of the last lamp of worship before the *stupa*.

Tagore had always criticized separateness, artificial caste system, evil practices in society; here is a quote from his lecture *Buddhadeb* addressed in 1935 which is very appropriate in this context:

Among all classes (varna), among all castes, the cruel stupidity of unholy separatedness in the name of religion has made this earth muddy with blood;

nowadays at every step humanity is insulted by a mutual hatred that is far more severe than violence against each other. Today, in this unfortunate country soiled by fraternal hatred, I anxiously yearn for this message of him who proclaimed friendliness (*maitri*) to all living beings to be the path to liberation. (sic) (Thakur 7)

Through this poem, Tagore appreciated Buddha's universal love for mankind; he knows that Buddhist ethics have no bar of colour or ancestry, caste or class .therefore; he severely criticizes Indian Brahmins for creating artificial caste system which is cause of discrimination. He further pointed out that Buddhism has freed people from slavery.

To Siam

Tagore cultivated esteem for the places where Buddhist culture and civilization flourished. He visited many countries in Europe and Asia; He observed that it is Buddha and his Dharma which will bring India closer to her Asian neighbors such as Java, Bali, Siam, Burma, Japan, China and other countries. On the occasion of his visit to the famous Borobudur temple in Java he observes and expresses his feelings through a poem:

To Siam (1927)

“I come today to the living temple that is one with Thee-
To the altar of united hearts
In which is seated on his lotus seat Lord Buddha,
Whose silence is peace, whose voice consolation
I come from a land where the Master's words
Lie dumb in desultory ruins, in the desolate dust,
Where oblivious ages smudged the meaning of the letters

Written on the pages of pillared stones,
 The records ,of a triumphant devotion.
 I come, a pilgrim, at thy gate, O Siam,
 To offer my verse to the endless glory of India.....” (Vishva-Bharati 187)

Tagore expressed his anguish about the disappearance of Buddhism in India, and he observed that these countries really assimilated and cultivated Buddhist philosophy, Culture, wisdom and literature and became prosperous however, the land of Buddha i.e. India, forgot to assimilate, practice it, therefore, he asked Indians to restore the Buddhist heritage, he writes:

European scholars have engaged in the act of excavating this resource and we are just waiting to follow in their footsteps. This is sufficient cause for great shame for our country. Could not there be at least even 5 people in the entire country who could take up this work of restoring the Buddhist writings as their lifelong commitments? Owing to our lack of knowledge about this area, the entire history of India remains impaired.
 (Ray Vol.1:223)

Novels

Tagore has published more realistic novels such *Rajarshi*, *Choker Bali* (Eyesore,1901), *Naikadubi* (The Wreck,1903), *Gora*(1910). *Dui Bon* (1933), *Malancha* (1934), *Char Adhyay* (Four Chapters, 1934). Through his one of the famous novels *Ghahre-Baire* (*Home and World*, 1910), he throws light on the Buddha’s eternal principle of peace and non-violence and the matters of self-identity (*jāti*), personal freedom; his protagonist of the novel declares-

It was Buddha who conquered the world, not Alexander. (Ray Vol.1:223)

By this quotation, he wants explain that, in the history of world, Buddha's revolution was extraordinary because there was no bloodshed, no human exploitation or torture. Those kings, who won by mere bloodshed and killing were not real heroes there empire did not last, however, the empire of love, compassion; universal friendliness, kindness of Buddha and his followers is unbroken.

Plays

Tagore was really a creative and genius playwright; he was possibly the most widely respected Indian literary personality of all time in the world. He handled numerous themes in his various dramas, the play '*Pujarini-Katha*' 1899 it shows Tagore's inclination toward Buddha's principles, ethics, values. Through other plays like *Chitrangada* (1936), *Shyama* (1939), *Chandalika* (1933), *the Malini*, *Visarjan* (1890) *Buddhabhakti-Vanajatak* (1938) which were based on Buddhist teaching, historical events, Jataka tales, he severely criticized the evil traditions and customs of india, especially caste system, narrow sectarianism inequality in the society, he also tried to put forth the positive side of Buddha's doctrine

Chandalika (An Untouchable Girl, 1933)

This play has been based on the theme of Untouchability, main character of the play is the untouchable girl, Prakriti, who is disturbed due to her discrimination by higher caste, who has to face continuous humiliation in the society. However, one day when The Buddhist monk Anand asks Prakriti to give him some water from the ritually contaminated well. This very question of Ananda: *jol dao* 'give me some water' becomes thought provoking,

She starts to envision other possible way of life, a way of self-respect and freedom, she gains confidence and becomes rebellious and defies obedience of a higher caste and goes

against the traditional religious and social rules and discrimination. She thinks to lead her won course of life. He frees herself from the shackles due to the message of Buddha which Annad explained to her i.e that nobody is born impure and nobody needs to undergo social isolation and inequity. Thereafter, Prakriti bursts out:

Many Chandalas abound in the country in the houses of Brahmins;

I cannot be a Chandala. (Buddhist Publication Society Vol.1:70)

This play is based on famous Buddhist tale of Prakriti and Monk Anand. It remains the fine example of Buddhist teaching, it highlights that one becomes great by his/her act not by his cast or class. It is a play about self-respect, freedom of choice. Tagore who was disappointed due to established Brahmanical malpractices and discrimination against lower castes in India; he aptly criticized these misconceptions in the play.

Natir Puja (*The Worship of the Dancing Girl*, 1926)

It is a dramatic form of the poem, '*Pujarini*' (1899). The play is about the dance-girl Shrimati who disobeys the king's unfair orders against the worship of the Buddhist stupa. After killing the king Bimbisara his own father, the king Ajatashatru has returned to the traditional orthopractical Brahminism. His father was patron of Buddhism, however, after his death, Ajatashatru started performing animal-sacrifices but the dance-girl Shrimati, does not follow his orders and she rebels against it.

She is devout lover Buddhism, believes in the principles of Buddha and makes her choice, however, for that eventually she has to lose her life. Through this play, Tagore very minutely shows the impact of Buddhist teaching and its greatness. He also states through his

both the characters i.e. Prakriti and Shrimati, that though many attempts are done to eradicate or prohibit Buddhist teachings, however, they will not be wiped out.

BUDDHA AND BUDDHISM: TAGORE'S VIEW

Shantineketan

Tagore had been time and again referring Buddha's ethics in his various books, lectures, sermons. He stated that:

Buddhism to be one of the greatest religious achievements of man

(Tagore Vol.3:491)

He was fond of Buddha and Buddhist philosophy; He established an international University "Visva Bharati" at Santiniketan, on the model of the Buddhist *Viharas* (Monasteries) which was great center of learning in those days, through this "Viswa Bharati" he promoted spiritual values and the creation of a new world culture, founded in multi-culturalism, diversity and tolerance.

He also built an experimental school for children at Santiniketan (Abode of Peace). He started a course of Buddhist studies and revived Pali studies at Shantiniketan. He invited many Buddhist scholars from Buddhist countries to Shantiniketan, further, due to his profound reverence for Buddhism; he invited Maha Stavira, an erudite Buddhist monk, to teach *Ahidharma*, Buddhist metaphysics in Viswa Bharati at Santiniketan.

Buddhist Holy Sites: in India and Abroad

Tagore always respected Buddha Gaya, Sarnath, and other Buddhist holy site in india and abroad therefore, he articulates his deep feelings about Buddha:

I am a disciple of the Buddha. But when I present myself before those holy places where the relics and foot-prints of the Buddha are found I come in touch with him to a great extent. (Buddhist Publication Society Vol.1:130)

While talking about Buddhism and its historical importance and its real motive, Tagore says:

Buddhism was the first spiritual force known to us in history which drew close together such a large number of races separated by most difficult barriers of distance, by differences of language and custom, by various degrees and divergent types of civilization. It had its motive power not in international commerce, nor in empire-building, nor in scientific curiosity, nor in a migratory impulse to occupy fresh territory. It was a purely disinterested effort to help mankind forward to its final goal. (Tagore, Ray Vol.7: 559-560)

Every year Tagore used to celebrate Buddha Purnima (Birth Anniversary of Lord Buddha) and composed something on Buddha. Tagore's intense feelings about Lord Buddha were expressed by him, in his address to Dharamrajik Chaitya Bihar; Calcutta on Buddha Purnima On 8th May, 1935. Tagore addressed the audience and gave in his presidential homage to the Blessed One:

In this full moon night, on the occasion of the celebration of his birth anniversary, I have come to bow at his feet whom I hold in my heart as the greatest of men. This is not a ritualistic gesture of some specific feast. It is the same offer that I have dedicated to him again which I once again articulates here. Once I been to Buddhagaya to see the temple there. My feeling that day was why was I not born at

the time when he had been physically present, walked the streets of this Gaya, the touch of whose feet had once purified this world? why could not I have the good fortune of feeling the radiation of his Holy presence directly in my body and soul?

“Those who are really great men are, at the very moment of their birth, placed above the continuing endless flow of time stretching from remote past to unforeseeable future. It was that very night in the temple that this truth flashed upon me. I saw a poor fisherman who had come from the faraway land of Japan across sea to make penance for some wrong or sin he had committed. Evening gave way to lovely silent midnight; still he continued to pray intently with folded hands. I take my refuge with Buddha. (Ray Vol.1:248)

This address exhibits Tagore's intense love and reverence for Lord Buddha and his teachings. He holds Lord Buddha in his heart as the greatest of men ever born on this earth. He offers him the homage again and again in the deep privacy of his soul. With reference to Tagore's visit to Buddha Gaya, Sri.Krishna Kripalani writes in *The Visva-bharati Quarterly* (1943):

Only once in his life, said Rabindranath, did he feel like prostrating himself before an image, and that was when he saw the Buddha at Gaya. (179)

CONCLUSION:

Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore was possibly the most widely respected Indian literary personality of all time in the world. Buddha and his philosophy played an important role in Tagore's spiritual outlook. He was greatly influenced by it in the most literal sense. It had been his second source of inspiration after Upanishads in his life. He holds Lord Buddha in

his heart as the greatest of men on ever born on this earth. The Buddha's teachings were earth-bound, rational, and pragmatic. The humanistic philosophy of Buddha gave universal respect for all humanity in all countries. Tagore never dwelled over theoretical philosophy of Buddhism, nor did he delve upon the issue of suffering (dukkha). He just took Buddhist Philosophy in a positive and constructive way and propagated Buddhism as an elixir to miseries of people.

Having influenced by Buddhist philosophy, Tagore executed Buddhist *Jatak Kathas*, ethical themes in his poems, Plays, Essays, travelogues, ballads, novels, short stories, and lectures. He respected and emphasized the everlasting merits of Buddhism through the *Visarjan*, *Chandalika* (1933), *Buddhabhakti-Vanajatak* (1938) *Malini*, and *Natir Puja*, (The Dancing Girl's Worship), through his poem *Pujarini*, Tagore appreciated Buddha's universal love for mankind and severely criticized Indian Brahmins for creating artificial caste system which is cause of discrimination. He stresses the importance of Buddhism for liberating people from slavery. Through *Nagarlakshmi* he propagated universal humanism, compassion and friendliness. Through play *Chandalika*, he focused the theme of an untouchability and talked about self-respect, freedom of choice. Through his novel *Ghaire-Baire (Home and World)*, he throws light on the Buddha's eternal principle of peace and non-violence.

According to him, the empire of love, compassion (*karuna*); universal friendliness/*metta*, kindness of Buddha and his followers was unbroken because Buddha's pleasing message of hope, respect for ordinary people and universal sympathy was so genuine that it directly reached to the heart of even illiterate people and due to this very fact that Buddhism spread over the rest of Asia and other countries.

Thus, it can be said that Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore has woven the reflections of Buddha and Buddhist teachings in his whole literature, giving the message of universal friendliness/*metta*, peace, harmony, equanimity, unselfishness, loving kindness, universal

sympathy, wisdom, empathic joy, goodness, compassion, respect for ordinary people and ever inspiring hope of the mankind. This magnificent contribution of Tagore to the Indian and world literature is more relevant than ever.

BIBLIOGRAPHY:

Aronson, A. *Rabindranath Through Western Eyes*. Allahabad: Kitabistan, 1943. Print.

Barua, Sudhansu Bimal. "Rabindranath Tagore and Buddhist Culture". *Bodhi Leaf, World Buddhism, Vol. X, No. 10* (1961). BPS Kandy, Sri Lanka Online Edition c (2011). Web. 5 April. 2016.

Bijlert, Victor van. "Emancipating the individual: Tagore's use of Buddhism as a modern liberation theology". (2012). pdf retrieved online. Web. 4 April. 2016.

<<http://www.godgeleerdheid.vu.nl/nl/Images/Victor-Bijlert-Emancipating-the-individual-Tagore's-use-of-Buddhism-as-a-modern-liberation-theology-tcm60-217752.pdf>>

Buddhist Publication Society. *Collected Bodhi Leaves Volume I: Numbers 1–30*. Kandy, Sri Lanka: Buddhist Publication Society, 1960. 130. Print.

Buddhist Publication Society. *Bodhi Leaves, Issues 5–11; Issue 15*. Kandy, Sri Lanka: Buddhist Publication Society, 1960. 70. Print.

Chakravarty, Amiya, ed. *A Tagore Reader*, Boston: Beacon Press, 1966. Print.

Champakura, Jose. *The God of Rabindranath Tagore: A Study of the Evolution of his Understanding of God*. Kolkata: Visva-Bharati. 2002. Print.

Colossi, Luciano, ed. *Universality of Tagore*. Calcutta: Don Bosco, 1991. Print.

Das, Sisir Kumar, ed. *The English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore. Vol. 1. Poems*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi. 1994. Print.

Das, Sisir Kumar, ed. *The English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore. Vol. 2. Plays, Stories, Essays*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1996. 278. Print.

Das, Sisir Kumar, ed. *The English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore*. Vol. 3. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1996: 491.Print.

Devi. S., and Lal. P. *Tagore's Last Poems*. Calcutta: Writers' Workshop, 1972.Print.

Dukas Helen., and Hoffman Banesh, eds. *Albert Einstein, The Human Side*. Princeton University Press, 1954.Print.

Dutta, K., Robinson, A. *Rabindranath Tagore: The Myriad-Minded Man*. St. Martin's Press, 1995.Print.

Dutta, Krishna., and Andrew Robinson. *Selected Letters of Rabindranath Tagore*. U.K: Cambridge University Press, 1997.Print.

Dutta, K ,Robinson, A ,eds. *Rabindranath Tagore: An Anthology*, St. Martin's Press,1997.Print.

Frost, Mark. "That Great Ocean of Idealism": *Calcutta, the Tagore Circle and the Idea of Asia, 1900 – 1920*, NSC Working Paper No. 3 Nalanda-Sriwijaya Centre. June 2011.Print.
<http://nsc.iseas.edu.sg/documents/working_papers/nscwps003.pdf>

Ghosh,Ashva .*Buddhacharita or Acts of the Buddha.(Reprint of complete English translation based on Sanskrit, Tibetan and Chinese Sources, 1936)*.Trans.Surya Narain Chaudhary . Delhi: Motilal Banarasidass, 2000. Print.

Ghose, Sisir Kumar.*Rabindranath Tagore*. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 2006. Print.

Gupta, Shakti Das. *Tagore's Asian Outlook*. Calcutta, 1961.Print

Gupta,Kalyan Sen. *The philosophy of Rabindranath Tagore*. USA, 2005.Print.

Gyatso, Geshe Kelsang. *Introduction to Buddhism: an explanation of the Buddhist Way of life*, New Delhi:Motilal Banarsidass Publishers, , 1999.Print.

Hay, Stephen N. *Asian ideas of East & West*.Harvard:1970.Print.

Krishna Kripalani. *Visva Bharathi Quarterly*, Kalikata: Visva-Bharati. April 1943: 179.Print
<<http://www.bps.lk/olib/bl/bl010-p.html>>

K. Kripalani, *Tagore: A Biography*, London: Oxford University Press, 1961.Print.

Kumar, Niraj. *Arise, Asia!* Delhi: 2002.Print.

Kumar,Niraj.“Was Tagore Buddhist? Tagore was Buddhist!” Paper presented at HBCA/Tibet House organized conference on "Tagore's engagement with Buddhist Culture" at India International Centre (17-18 March 2012): Web. 5 April 2016

<<http://ariseasia.blogspot.in/2012/03/was-tagore-buddhist-tagore-was-buddhist.htm>> .

Kundu, Rama. “Thine immeasurable Mercy and Goodness: Buddha in Tagore’s imagination.” *Studies on Rabindra Nath Tagore*. ed. Ray Mohit K. Vol.I. Delhi: 2004.213-252.Print.

Madan, Gurmukh. “Buddhism: Its Various Manifestations” *Volume 1 of Encyclopaedia of agricultural marketing / edited by Jagdish Prasad*, New Delhi:Mittal Publications, 1999:205.Print

Mahathera, K. Sri Dhammananda. *What Buddhists Believe*. Buddhist Missionary Society, 1982.Print.

Mazumdar, Pampa. *Rabindrasamskritir Bharatiya Rup o Utsa*. Kalikata: Jijnasa, 1972.Print.

Mitra, Rajendralala. *The Sanskrit Buddhist Literature of Nepal*. Calcutta: The Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1882. Print.

Mitra, Rajendralala. *Ashtasahasrika: a collection of discourses on the metaphysics of the Mahayana school of the Buddhists*. Bibliotheca Indica 110. Calcutta: Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1888.Print.

Naravane, V.S. *Modern Indian Thought*. Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1967.Print.

Okakura, Kakuzo. *The Ideals of the East*. London:Dover Publications, 1903.print.

Pal, Prashanta Kumar. *Rabijibani*. Vol.5. Kolkata: Ananda Publishers Limited, 1990: 1308-1314.Print.

Radhakrishnan, S. *The Philosophy of Rabindranath Tagore*. London: Macmillan, 1919.Print.

Ray, Mohit K. *Studies on Rabindranath Tagore* Vol.1. Atlantic Publishers & Distri, 2004:

213.213-214.216. 223. 227.248. Print.

Sen, Probodh Chandra., Bisi Pramathanath., Bhattacharyaya, Bijanbehari., Dutta, Hirendranath., and Sen, Amiya Kumar, Eds. *Rabindra Rachanabali* (The collected works of Tagore) 1 to 15 Vol. Calcutta: West Bengal Government, 1961. Print.

Subbiah, S., Saptarshi Mallick., and Solayan, M., *Rabindranath Tagore and Indian Literature*, Chennai: Universal Publishers, 2012. Print.

---. *Rabindranath Tagore's contribution to Literature, Culture and Education*. Karaikudi, 2012. Print.

Suzuki, Teitaro. *Outlines of Mahayana Buddhism*. London: Luzac and Company. 1907. Print.

Suzuki, Daisetz Teitaro. *The Awakening of Faith: The Classic Exposition of Mahayana Buddhism*. Mineola (reprint from 1900 edition), New York: Dover Publications, 2003. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *Sadhana the Realisation of life*. London: Macmillan, 1916. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *The Home and the World*, London: Macmillan, 1919. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *Gitabitan* (A collection of all Tagore's songs). Vol.3. Calcutta: VisvaBharati, 1932. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *A Poet's Religion*. Ed. S. Radhakrishnan. London: Allen and Unwin, 1952. Print.

---. *A Tagore Testament*. Trans. Indu Dutta. London: Meridian, 1953. Print.

---. *Creative Unity*. London: Macmillan, 1926. Print.

---. *Lover's Gift and Crossing*. London: Macmillan, 1930. Print.

---. *Personality*. London: Macmillan, 1933. Print.

---. *Reminiscence*. London: Macmillan, 1933. Print.

---. *Sadhana*. London: Macmillan, 1918. Print.

---. *Stray Birds*. London: Macmillan, 1933. Print.

---. *The Gardener*. London: Macmillan, 1919. Print.

---. *The Religion of an Artist*. Calcutta: Visva-Bharati, 1953. Print.

---. *The Religion of Man*. London: George Allen and Unwin, 1932. Print.

Tagore, R. *Collected Poems and Plays of Rabindranath Tagore*, Macmillan Publishing, 1977. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *Three Plays: Mukta-dhara; Natir Puja; Chandaliika*. Trans. Marjorie Sykes. Madras: Oxford University Press, 1989. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *I Won't Let You Go, Selected Poems*. Trans. Ketaki Kushari Dyson. Upon Tyne: Bloodaxe Books, 1991. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. "The English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore: A miscellany" *Volume 3 of The English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore*. ed. Sisir Kumar Das. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1994. 491. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *Selected Poems*. UK: Penguin, 2005. Print.

Tagore, Rabindranath. *Sadhana*. 1st World Publishing, 2006. 08. Print.

Tagore, and Ray M.K. "Lectures, addresses" *Volume 7 of The English Writings of Rabindranath Tagore*, Atlantic Publishers & Dist, 2007. 559-560. Print.

Thakur, Ravindranath. *Buddhadeb*. Kalikata: Visva-Bharati. 1985. 15-16. Print.

Verma, M. *A Bunch of Poems*. Calcutta: Writers' Workshop, 1966. Print.

Visva-Bharati. *The Visva-bharati Quarterly*. Kalikata: Visva-bharati, 1956. 187. Print

W. Radice. *Selected Poems*. Penguin Modern Classics, 1985. Print.